Old Mysore in southern Karnataka.[42] The BJP capitalised on the erosion of the caste alliance Urs had stitched together for the Congress, as well as the decline of the Congress (O), Ramakrishna Hegde's Janata Dal and JD(S) to emerge as the primary anti-Congress force in Karnataka.

By contrast, the Congress's support base remained more evenly spread out across Karnataka, among other OBC castes, like Siddaramaiah's Kuruba community, as well as among Dalits and Muslims. However, because these communities are generally more dispersed across constituencies, in several state elections after 2004, the Congress has ended up in the peculiar position of winning more overall vote share than the BJP but considerably fewer seats. This happened in 2004, 2008 and 2018.[43] The only exception was 2013, when Yediyurappa had briefly separated from the BJP to form his own regional outfit and split the BJP vote. Simply put, winning the Lingayat vote has been the making of the BJP in Karnataka.

Karnataka's Mini-Ayodhya: Hubli's Idgah Maidan, Hindutva and the Making of the BJP

If the Ayodhya movement was the turning point for the BJP in north India, in Karnataka it would be the five-year-long dispute over Hubli's Idgah Maidan or the Kittur Rani Chennamma Maidan, which flared up between 1992 and 1995. Chatting over lunch in his office, C.N. Ashwathnarayan, then deputy chief minister of Karnataka, attributed the rise of the BJP in big part to the party having a 'no appeasement policy of minorities'.[44] This is a common response from state party leaders when asked why Karnataka is different from the other south Indian states and what explains the BJP's rise here. 'By and large, Karnataka has a mindset of the rightist ideology from the beginning,' said Lehar Singh Siroya, senior BJP MLC and former state unit treasurer, who was said to be close to both B.S. Yediyurappa, former chief minister, and the central party leadership. 'It's not like West Bengal or others. *Yahan rightist vichardhara hai* [we have right-wing thinking here]. The reason for our growth is a